

CENTRAL ASIA, EURASIA AND CONNECTIVITY

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE → THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES → POLICY CLASSIFICATION: WHAT BROAD-BASED → ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO → SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS → DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g2 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE ROOT ACCESS CONDITION

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE ROOT ACCESS CONDITION HOW DOES A STATE WITH NO LAND ACCESS BUILD ROOT CONDITION PAKISTAN AND AFGHANISTAN LIE BETWEEN INDIA AND THE FIVE AXIS 1 CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, 2012, BROAD-BASED AXIS 2 SCO SEAT

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL QUESTION → how does a state with no land access build Eurasian presence?
- ROOT CONDITION → Pakistan and Afghanistan lie between India and the five Republics
- AXIS 1 → POLICY: Connect Central Asia Policy, 2012, broad-based

MECHANISM

- AXIS 2 → FORUMS: SCO seat
- India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue
- AXIS 3 → CORRIDORS: INSTC

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Ashgabat Agreement
- RULE → the constraint is the spine of the answer, not an afterthought
- MUST REMEMBER: Central Asia and Eurasia policy connects continental access, energy,...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the constraint is the spine of the answer, not an afterthought.

01

STAGE 01 THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES AND WHY BOTH FAIL

THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES AND WHY BOTH FAIL ROUTE A VIA AFGHANISTAN AND PAKISTAN FAILS ON TRANSIT UNAVAILABILITY AND AFGHAN INSTABILITY ROUTE B VIA XINJIANG, THEN ACROSS THE KARAKORAM AND HIMALAYAN RANGES EXTREME GEOGRAPHY PLUS REQUIRED CHINESE COOPERATION

CORE CLAIM

ROUTE A → via Afghanistan and Pakistan
FAILS ON: transit unavailability and Afghan instability

MECHANISM

ROUTE B → via Xinjiang, then across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges
FAILS ON: extreme geography plus required Chinese cooperation

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

SOURCE → Sikri on any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan
VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution

CORE CLAIM

- ROUTE A → via Afghanistan and Pakistan
- FAILS ON: transit unavailability and Afghan instability

MECHANISM

- ROUTE B → via Xinjiang, then across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges
- FAILS ON: extreme geography plus required Chinese cooperation

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- SOURCE → Sikri on any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan
- VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution.

02

STAGE 02 POLICY CLASSIFICATION: WHAT BROAD-BASED ACTUALLY MEANS

POLICY CLASSIFICATION WHAT BROAD-BASED ACTUALLY MEANS CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012 SUSTAINED HIGH-LEVEL ENGAGEMENT WITH THE FIVE REPUBLICS COUNTER-TERRORISM AND SECURITY-COUNCIL-LEVEL CONSULTATION MARKET INTEGRATION PROPOSAL WITH THE EURASIAN SPACE PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE AND CULTURAL CONNECTIONS FIVE REPUBLICS

CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012

POLITICAL → sustained high-level engagement with the five Republics

SECURITY → counter-terrorism and security-council-level consultation

ECONOMIC → market integration proposal with the Eurasian space

CORE CLAIM

- CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012
- POLITICAL → sustained high-level engagement with the five Republics
- SECURITY → counter-terrorism and security-council-level consultation

MECHANISM

- ECONOMIC → market integration proposal with the Eurasian space
- CULTURAL → people-to-people and cultural connections
- FIVE REPUBLICS → Kazakhstan

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope.

03

STAGE 03 ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION

ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION COMPREHENSIVE ECONOMIC COOPERATION AGREEMENT WITH THE EURASIAN SPACE 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG INDIA-EAEU FREE-TRADE NEGOTIATION FORMALLY BEGINS 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW SECOND ROUND HELD

UNDER NEGOTIATION; NEITHER SIGNED NOR IN FORCE

PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement

3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation

22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held

STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Customs

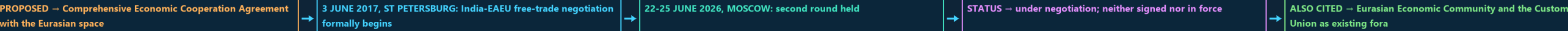
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope.

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UNDER NEGOTIATION; NEITHER SIGNED NOR IN FORCE



CORE CLAIM

- PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space
- 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins

MECHANISM

- 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held
- STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora
- RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement.

04

STAGE 04 SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026

SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026 FULL MEMBERS (10) OBSERVERS (2) DIALOGUE PARTNERS PAKISTAN 2017 IRAN 2023 BELARUS 2024 1 SEPTEMBER 2025

OBSERVERS (2)	Afghanistan	Mongolia
DIALOGUE PARTNERS	15	
ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017	Iran 2023	Belarus 2024

CORE CLAIM

- FULL MEMBERS (10)
- OBSERVERS (2)
- DIALOGUE PARTNERS

MECHANISM

- ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017
- Iran 2023
- Belarus 2024

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- 1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → decision envisaging a single SCO Partner status
- PENDING → the enabling amendments had not entered into force
- TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted

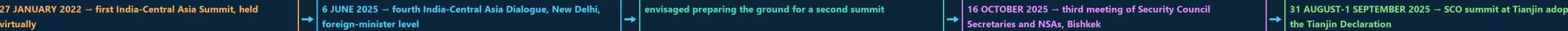
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted.

05

STAGE 05 DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP

DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP 27 JANUARY 2022 FIRST INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT, HELD VIRTUALLY 6 JUNE 2025 FOURTH INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA DIALOGUE, NEW DELHI, FOREIGN-MINISTER LEVEL ENVISAGED PREPARING THE GROUND FOR A SECOND SUMMIT 16 OCTOBER 2025

THIRD MEETING OF SECURITY COUNCIL SECRETARIES AND NSAS, BISHKEK



CORE CLAIM

- 27 JANUARY 2022 → first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually
- 6 JUNE 2025 → fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level
- envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit

MECHANISM

- 16 OCTOBER 2025 → third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek
- 31 AUGUST-1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration
- Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26 with the next summit scheduled for Bishkek

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026.

06

STAGE 06 CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT 13 MAY 2024 TEN-YEAR LONG-TERM CONTRACT, INDIA PORTS GLOBAL LIMITED WITH IRAN'S PORTS AND MARITIME ORGANISATION USD 120 MILLION ANNOUNCED EQUIPMENT INVESTMENT; LEVEL USD 250 MILLION

ANNOUNCED CREDIT WINDOW FOR MUTUALLY IDENTIFIED INFRASTRUCTURE

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with	USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement	LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance
Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation	USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure	RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

CORE CLAIM

MECHANISM

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

06

STAGE 06 CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

13 MAY 2024

TEN-YEAR LONG-TERM CONTRACT, INDIA PORTS GLOBAL LIMITED WITH

IRAN'S PORTS AND MARITIME ORGANISATION

USD 120 MILLION

ANNOUNCED EQUIPMENT INVESTMENT; LEVEL

USD 250 MILLION

ANNOUNCED CREDIT WINDOW FOR MUTUALLY IDENTIFIED INFRASTRUCTURE

CORE CLAIM

13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with
Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation

MECHANISM

USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement
USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance
RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

CORE CLAIM

- 13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with
- Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation

MECHANISM

- USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement
- USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance
- RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels.

07

STAGE 07 SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE

SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE

16 SEPTEMBER 2025

UNITED STATES STATE DEPARTMENT REVOKES THE 2018 WAIVER

29 SEPTEMBER 2025

REVOCATION TAKES EFFECT

NON-EXPOSURE RUNS ONLY TO 26 APRIL 2026

BEYOND THAT DATE

STATUS REQUIRES FRESH VERIFICATION

16 SEPTEMBER 2025 → United States State Department revokes the 2018 waiver

29 SEPTEMBER 2025: revocation takes effect

ASSURANCE: non-exposure runs only to 26 April 2026

BEYOND THAT DATE: status requires fresh verification

LEGAL CHARACTER → another state's domestic sanctions posture; exposure for entities

CORE CLAIM

- 16 SEPTEMBER 2025 → United States State Department revokes the 2018 waiver
- 29 SEPTEMBER 2025: revocation takes effect
- ASSURANCE: non-exposure runs only to 26 April 2026

MECHANISM

- BEYOND THAT DATE: status requires fresh verification
- LEGAL CHARACTER → another state's domestic sanctions posture; exposure for entities
- NOT → an international legal obligation binding on India

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- CONSEQUENCE → the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CONSEQUENCE → the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question.

08

STAGE 08 CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER

CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER

ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK

INTERNATIONAL NORTH-SOUTH TRANSPORT CORRIDOR INTENDED TO REACH CENTRAL ASIA

OPERATING SEGMENTS EXIST

NOT A COMPLETED, FULL-CAPACITY CORRIDOR

25 APRIL 2011

ASHGABAT AGREEMENT SIGNED; INDIA JOINED FROM 3 FEBRUARY 2018

A FACILITATION FRAMEWORK, NOT AN INFRASTRUCTURE-FINANCE MECHANISM

ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK → International North-South Transport Corridor intended to reach Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing

OPERATING SEGMENTS exist

NOT a completed, full-capacity corridor

25 APRIL 2011 → Ashgabat Agreement signed

CORE CLAIM

- ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK → International North-South Transport Corridor intended to reach Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan
- OPERATING SEGMENTS exist
- NOT a completed, full-capacity corridor

MECHANISM

- 25 APRIL 2011 → Ashgabat Agreement signed
- India joined from 3 FEBRUARY 2018 multimodal transport and transit corridor to the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
- LIMIT: a facilitation framework, not an infrastructure-finance mechanism

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- RULE → capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification.

09

STAGE 09 COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

THE REGION ABUTS MAJOR ASIAN POWERS AND WILL ALWAYS

SUSTAINED DIPLOMACY THROUGH A SEAT, A DIALOGUE AND CORRIDOR

RUSSIAN AND CHINESE PROXIMITY IS GREATER THAN INDIA'S

ACCEPT CO-DETERMINED OUTCOMES RATHER THAN CLAIMING REGIONAL PRIMACY

MIXED SCO MEMBERSHIP INCLUDES PAKISTAN

THE FORUM SUSTAINS ENGAGEMENT; IT CANNOT RESOLVE TRANSIT ACCESS

MULTI-ACTOR COMPETITION, EXPRESSLY NOT INDIAN DETERMINISM

CORE CLAIM

- PROBLEM → the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences
- RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments
- PROBLEM → Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's

MECHANISM

- RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy
- PROBLEM → mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan
- RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism
- CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...

09

STAGE 09

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CORE CLAIM

• PROBLEM → the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences

• RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments

• PROBLEM → Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's

MECHANISM

• RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy

• PROBLEM → mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan

• RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism

• CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism.

10

STAGE 10

FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST

FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST

INDIA AND CHINA SEEK ENERGY FROM THE SAME SOURCES

THAT COMPETITION ONLY BENEFITS THE ENERGY PRODUCERS

SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION

DEVELOP AN UNDERSTANDING ON ENERGY WITH CHINA

COOPERATION ON ONE FUNCTION ALONGSIDE UNRESOLVED STRATEGIC MISTRUST

THE WIDER INDIA-CHINA STRATEGIC RELATIONSHIP BELONGS TO TOPIC 03

AVOIDS THE CRUDE CHOICE BETWEEN PURE RIVALRY AND NAIVE

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources	COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust	EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia...
EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers	BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03	
SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China	USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership	

CORE CLAIM

• COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources

• EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers

• SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China

MECHANISM

• COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust

• BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03

• USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia.

11

STAGE 11

ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND

STATE THE ABSENCE OF DIRECT LAND ACCESS BEFORE LISTING

POLICY, FORUMS AND CORRIDORS, EACH WITH ONE DATED INSTRUMENT

PRICE SANCTIONS EXPOSURE, THE UNHELD SUMMIT AND THE OPEN

CONVERT GOODWILL INTO RELIABLE ACCESS AS THE GRADED VERDICT

OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly

CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

CORE CLAIM

• OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

• BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

MECHANISM

• TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly

• CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

• OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

• BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

THE BROAD MULTILATERAL BODY THROUGH WHICH INDIA ENGAGES CENTRAL

INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE

THE MORE DIRECT

INSTC AND CHABAHAR PORT

CONNECTIVITY FRAMEWORKS UNDER CONTINUING

INDIA-UZBEKISTAN BILATERAL BRIEF (AS ON APRIL 2026)

THE MOST RECENT

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

• SCO: the broad multilateral body through which India engages Central

• India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue: the more direct,

• INSTC and Chabahar port: connectivity frameworks under continuing

• India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026): the most recent

ADVANCED DEBATE

• India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation: the current form

• Direct PYQ boundary case (2024 Q10): the question asks for a "critical"

• CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan's ambiguous status: Afghanistan sits at the

• CAUTION: Boundary case — India-China energy cooperation despite rivalry: Sikri's

LEGACY / NUANCE

• CAUTION: Boundary case — SCO membership without privileged access: India's SCO

• CAUTION: No unilateral connectivity solution exists: both direct land routes

• CAUTION: SCO engagement is diluted by mixed membership: India's participation

• CAUTION: Energy-source competition with China risks negative-sum outcomes

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.